

# Preamp

A colour preamp with four voicings, a three-band EQ boost and a VU meter.



## Overview

Preamp is a stage you put in front of anything that needs warmth, weight or a bit of dirt. Choose one of four voicings, set how hard to drive it, and shape the top end with TONE.

CLEAN adds no drive at all - use it with the EQ BOOST as a clean boost. VIBE recreates the preamp of a classic 60s pedal: extra low-mid weight, a soft, lopsided saturation and a rounded top that gets darker as you drive it. ZEN is a smooth, symmetrical, amp-like breakup. TRANS is a single-transistor drive: lopsided, it bites earlier and turns furry when pushed.

In every voicing except CLEAN a gentle, program-dependent compression (sag) sits in front of the drive, and it grows as you turn DRIVE up, like a real preamp running out of headroom. The EQ BOOST in front adds three gentle peaks a decade apart to push the source into the drive.

### Reach for it for

- Warming up DI guitar, bass and keys
- Driving synths and drum loops into gentle grit
- A clean, broad EQ lift on a bus (CLEAN with BOOST)
- Fuzzy, transistor-style edge on a lead
- A little analogue movement with DRIFT

## Controls

### VOICE

|                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>CLEAN</b>                                   | No drive and no sag. TONE does nothing here; use it with BOOST as a clean EQ preamp.                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>VIBE</b>                                    | The 60s pedal preamp: a low-end lift (below about 250 Hz, growing with DRIVE), soft, uneven (even-harmonic) saturation and a top end that rolls off from about 18 kHz down to 7 kHz as DRIVE rises. TONE does nothing in this voicing - the drive sets the top end. |
| <b>ZEN</b>                                     | Gentle, symmetrical saturation with a smooth, amp-like breakup.                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>TRANS</b>                                   | Single-transistor drive: lopsided, it starts biting earlier and gets furry when pushed.                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>BOOST</b>                                   | Switches the EQ boost in or out. It sits in front of the drive, so a boost also drives the voicing harder.                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>30/300/3K,<br/>50/500/5K,<br/>70/700/7K</b> | The three frequencies the boost lifts at once, each a decade apart: low, mid and high together.                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>+1 dB, +3 dB, +6 dB</b>                     | How much each of the three bands is lifted.                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

### VU meter

Shows the input level after TRIM and GUARD, with 0 VU at -18 dBFS. Under it, the panel names the voicing and how hard it is working: WARM, PUSHED or SATURATED, by the DRIVE setting (CLEAN reads NO DRIVE).

### DRIVE

|              |                                                                                                                  |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>DRIVE</b> | How hard the voicing is driven, 0 to 100% (40% by default). It also deepens the sag compression in front of it.  |
| <b>TONE</b>  | A top-end roll-off for ZEN and TRANS, sweeping its corner from about 1.2 kHz (dark) to 14 kHz (open), 0 to 100%. |

**OUT lights**

Six lights showing the output peak level: -36, -24, -12, -6, 0 and +3 dB.

## Drift

**DRIFT**

0 to 100%. 50% is the standard amount; 100% is twice that, 0 turns it off. It makes the saturation's lopsidedness (bias) wander slowly and the sag compression breathe in and out. Higher settings also make the wander move faster.

## IN / OUT

**TRIM**

Input level before anything else, from -24 to +12 dB.

**GUARD**

Click the TRIM knob (without turning it) to switch GUARD on or off; the small light at the knob's upper right shows it is on and glows brighter while it works. On by default. Gently eases very hot sources down towards about -18 dBFS average and catches fast peaks above -6 dBFS, so loud sources never overdrive the plugin. It never boosts quiet sources.

**SAT**

Band saturation on the way out: only the lows and highs are saturated (the mids stay clean), with a soft curve that loosens as the level rises.

**OFF / CLIP / LIMIT**

The final stage: nothing, a soft clipper that holds the peaks just under 0 dBFS (no latency), or a lookahead limiter (3 ms latency, compensated by REAPER). The CLIP key flashes red while the clipper is working.

## MASTER

**MIX**

Dry / preamp balance, 0 to 100% (100% by default). Lower settings blend the clean signal back in for parallel drive.

**OUTPUT**

Output level, -24 to +12 dB.

## The header

|                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PRESETS, ◀ ▶ and the display</b> | PRESETS (or a click on the display) opens the list of factory presets; ◀ and ▶ step through them. A preset sets the voicing, DRIVE, TONE, the EQ boost, the drift amounts and MIX; the drift speed, OUTPUT and the input and output stages are left as they are. The last entry resets everything to the defaults. |
| <b>S / M / L</b>                    | Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>?</b>                            | Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## Presets

|                              |                                                                                  |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Vibe Warm</b>             | VIBE at 35% drive: gentle warmth and weight.                                     |
| <b>Vibe Driven</b>           | VIBE at 85% drive with a little more drift: thick and saturated.                 |
| <b>Zen Edge</b>              | ZEN at 35% drive: just on the edge of breakup.                                   |
| <b>Zen Crunch</b>            | ZEN at 70% drive with a slightly brighter TONE.                                  |
| <b>Transistor Grit</b>       | TRANS at 50% drive with TONE a little dark.                                      |
| <b>Transistor Fuzz</b>       | TRANS at 95% drive with a darker TONE: full fuzz.                                |
| <b>Console Lift</b>          | CLEAN with BOOST on at 70/700/7K, +3 dB: a clean, broad lift.                    |
| <b>Mid Push into Zen</b>     | ZEN at 55% drive with the 50/500/5K boost pushing into it.                       |
| <b>Breathing Valve</b>       | VIBE at 55% drive with heavy bias and sag drift, so the colour moves.            |
| <b>Reset all to defaults</b> | Every control back to its starting value, including the input and output stages. |

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## Tips

- Use the VU: aim for the needle around 0 with TRIM before you set DRIVE, so the voicings react as designed.
- BOOST adds level as well as colour, so it drives the voicing harder too; pull DRIVE back a little when you switch it on.
- For parallel drive on drums or bass, turn DRIVE up and MIX down to 30 - 50%.
- TONE only works in ZEN and TRANS; in VIBE the drive itself darkens the top.

File: gfx-preamp.jsfx